feel immensely fulfilled and delighted.

A painful series

While I was gradually adjusting to the responsibilities of fatherhood, I suffered my first serious injury, a back problem from which I took more than eight months to fully recover. The problem surfaced in Chennai at the end of January 1999 during the first Test against Pakistan.

Pakistan had come to India after a gap of thirteen years and the entire country was focused on the two-Test series and the Asian Test Championship involving India, Pakistan and Sri Lanka that was to follow. Pakistan had a versatile bowling attack, with Wasim Akram, Waqar Younis and the off-spinner Saqlain Mushtaq, leg-spinner Shahid Afridi and slow left-arm orthodox spinner Nadeem Khan all in good form, and there was no doubt it would be a keenly contested series.

The Chennai match lived up to the hype and after three days of gripping Test cricket, India were left with a target of 271 in the fourth innings. It was a difficult run chase, as Wasim and Waqar started out very well for Pakistan, reducing us to 6–2 on the third evening. I walked out with just under an hour left on the third day, with Wasim and Waqar still charging in and full of energy. Rahul was already out there and we knew we needed to see out the rest of the day and resume battle the following morning. These little sessions are always tricky because the bowling side know they can come back refreshed the next morning and so they throw everything at the batsmen, in the hope of getting a bonus wicket. For the batting team there's little to be gained and the priority is not to lose another wicket.

Waqar welcomed me to the crease with a couple of bouncers and even walked up to me on one occasion to say, '*Ball nazar aayi?*' (Did you see the ball?) I didn't say a thing, but my eye contact was enough to give him the message. I hardly moved and he was soon walking back to his bowling mark. I remember muttering to myself, 'You are not bowling that quick, my friend.' This exchange only helped to strengthen my resolve and I was unbeaten on 20 at the end of play, determined to win the Test match on the fourth day.

Rahul was not out at the other end and there are not many other players you would rather bat with in a situation like that. He has always been rock solid. The next morning, however, the usual script was torn up